Harvest Day 2026

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This morning I want to look at a parable that may or may not be familiar to you.

Go ahead and turn to Matthew 20.

Just to give some context…a parable to put it simply is a earthly story with a heavenly meaning. Jesus was an expert teacher. He was the greatest teacher to ever walk the earth.

He would use common every day concepts and illustrations in order to teach a deeper spiritual truth.

He would take abstract truths and and make them tangible through familiar scenarios.

Even the disciples at times could not comprehend these parables and Jesus had to reveal to them the meaning.

The question is why did Jesus preach in parables? Why not just come straight out with the truth? Why mask deep spiritual things with earthly things?

The answer to this question ought to cause us to tremble…the disciples asked this very question in Matthew 13:10-17

Matthew 13:10–17 NASB95

10 And the disciples came and said to Him, “Why do You speak to them in parables?” 11 Jesus answered them, “To you it has been granted to know the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it has not been granted.

12 “For whoever has, to him *more* shall be given, and he will have an abundance; but whoever does not have, even what he has shall be taken away from him.

13 “Therefore I speak to them in parables; because while seeing they do not see, and while hearing they do not hear, nor do they understand.

14 “In their case the prophecy of Isaiah is being fulfilled, which says, ‘You will keep on
hearing, but will not understand; You will keep on seeing, but will not perceive;

15 For the heart of this people has become dull, With their ears they scarcely
hear, And they have closed their eyes, Otherwise they would see with their eyes,
Hear with their ears, And understand with their heart and return, And I would
heal them.’

16 “But blessed are your eyes, because they see; and your ears, because they hear.

17 “For truly I say to you that many prophets and righteous men desired to see what you see, and did not see *it*, and to hear what you hear, and did not hear *it*.

Now, this seems unfair. This seems almost like Jesus is pulling a fast one on certain people to keep them in spiritual blindness.

But here is the truth that Jesus is speaking here. This is not some arbitrary punishment but rather a reflection of spiritual principle. Those who were receptive to the Lord would gain more understanding. Those who were already resistant to the Lord would lose what little comprehension they did have.

Why is this important?

Well, Jesus after preaching and teaching would say something that he repeated quite often…

“those that have ears to hear, let them hear…”

You may be in here this morning and you are physically in the building, but your heart is far from God. My prayer is that you turn from that resistant heart posture and humble yourself before God.

You may be here and you are walking with the Lord. My prayer is that your faith is strengthened this morning and you become even closer with God.

Folks listen, God has something for each of us here this morning. So, knowing this. Believing this. Trusting this. May prayer echoes Jesus…

“those that have ears to hear, let them hear…”

Let’s look at this parable today…

Matthew 20:1–16 NASB95

1 “For the kingdom of heaven is like a landowner who went out early in the morning to
hire laborers for his vineyard.

2 “When he had agreed with the laborers for a denarius for the day, he sent them into
his vineyard. 3 “And he went out about the third hour and saw others standing idle in
the market place;

4 and to those he said, ‘You also go into the vineyard, and whatever is right I will give
you.’ And *so* they went. 5 “Again he went out about the sixth and the ninth hour, and did
the same thing.

6 “And about the eleventh *hour* he went out and found others standing *around;* and he
said to them, ‘Why have you been standing here idle all day long?’ 7 “They said to him,
‘Because no one hired us.’ He said to them, ‘You go into the vineyard too.’

8 “When evening came, the owner of the vineyard said to his foreman, ‘Call the laborers
and pay them their wages, beginning with the last *group* to the first.’ 9 “When those
hired about the eleventh hour came, each one received a denarius.

10 “When those *hired* first came, they thought that they would receive more; but each
of them also received a denarius. 11 “When they received it, they grumbled at the
landowner,

12 saying, ‘These last men have worked *only* one hour, and you have made them equal
to us who have borne the burden and the scorching heat of the day.’

13 “But he answered and said to one of them, ‘Friend, I am doing you no wrong; did you
not agree with me for a denarius? 14 ‘Take what is yours and go, but I wish to give to this
last man the same as to you.

15 ‘Is it not lawful for me to do what I wish with what is my own? Or is your eye envious

because I am generous?’ [16] “So the last shall be first, and the first last.”

Title:

Good Gifts From A Good God

Pray.

This parable starts and ends with the same truth…

Matthew 19:30 NASB95
[30] “But many *who are* first will be last; and *the* last, first.

Matthew 20:16 NASB95
[16] “So the last shall be first, and the first last.”

This parable brings us principles that are in complete opposition to how the world views things.

First we see

Their Dependency

This landowner went out early in the morning. A typical workday at this time would have started at 6 am which would be sunrise.

So this landowner was out looking for workers before 6 am.

The reason he did this was because also at this time, day laborers would gather in the marketplace before the start of the work day to be available for hire.

These day laborers typically were of low social-economic status who were most likely unskilled.

In other words, they were desperate for work.

These workers were completely dependent on the employers to come by and hire them for the day.

They were all waiting on a chance to get work. Well, we see that the landowner did find a group of workers to start at the 6 am hour.

This is where we see

Their Opportunity

The Bibel says that he agreed to pay the workers a denarius, which at that time would have been equal to a day's wage.

What an awesome thing!

These men completely dependent on someone coming and hiring them out gets the chance to make a days wage. So, they got to working…

Obviously, this landowner had much work to do because we see that three hours later he goes back to the marketplace to get more workers.

This would have been at 9 am.

Matthew 20:3–4 NASB95

3 "And he went out about the third hour and saw others standing idle in the market place;

4 and to those he said, 'You also go into the vineyard, and whatever is right I will give you.' And *so* they went.

Notice they were standing idle in the marketplace. They were not working. Remember, they are dependent on someone coming and hiring them and either they were not up early enough or they simply were not hired out in the first group.

Either way, they get an opportunity as well and they take it.

There is one difference in the hiring process here…they did not agree upon a denarius, but rather the landowner said he would pay whatever was right…

Since they started at 9 instead of 6 they expected to be paid less.

This landowner must have had a large vineyard because he ends up going back to the marketplace to hire more workers many times…

Matthew 20:5 NASB95

5 “Again he went out about the sixth and the ninth hour, and did the same thing.

So he has gone out and hired at 6 am, 9 am, noon, and 3 pm.

But there was still workers needed!

Matthew 20:6–7 NASB95

6 “And about the eleventh *hour* he went out and found others standing *around;* and he said to them, ‘Why have you been standing here idle all day long?’

7 “They said to him, ‘Because no one hired us.’ He said to them, ‘You go into the vineyard too.’

The eleventh hour would have been at 5 pm…one hour before the work day was done.

We see that all throughout the day there was opportunity for as many who were willing to come to the vineyard and work.

And guess what…now its pay time!

Matthew 20:8–9 NASB95

8 “When evening came, the owner of the vineyard said to his foreman, ‘Call the laborers and pay them their wages, beginning with the last *group* to the first.’

9 “When those *hired* about the eleventh hour came, each one received a denarius.

Now, let’s not be dishonest this morning…if you were there at this time and you saw the workers who had worked for one hour get a whole days pay what would you expect?

“Man, I am about to get a serious pay day!” “If they got a whole denarius, I’ll get two or three!”

Maybe I am the only one, but to me that would be the only sensible outcome.

But that is not what happened.

Matthew 20:10–12 NASB95

10 “When those *hired* first came, they thought that they would receive more; but each of them also received a denarius. 11 “When they received it, they grumbled at the landowner,

12 saying, ‘These last men have worked *only* one hour, and you have made them equal to us who have borne the burden and the scorching heat of the day.’

Why do they get the same as me? We have worked all day out here in this heat!

And look what they say… “*you have made them equal with us*…”

Church what we see here is

His Impartiality

There are only two religions in this world. The first is one that stems all the way back to Cain, and that is work-based. If I can do enough, if i can be good enough, if I save up enough spiritual equity…God will let me in heaven.

Every false religion today can be traced back to some form of work-based salvation.

True salvation is grace-based. Grace is the great equalizer. Grace is not earned, only given.

We see this in Ephesians 2:8-10

Ephesians 2:8–10 NASB95

8 For by grace you have been saved through faith; and that not of yourselves, *it is* the gift of God; 9 not as a result of works, so that no one may boast.

10 For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand so that we would walk in them.

This work-based mindset can easily deceive even those who know Christ if we are not careful.

Now, In this parable we see that there are many workers who get hired on for the work in the vineyard.

The landowner represent God, and the workers represent those who are saved. The vineyard is the world that we are to serve Christ in.

How did the landowner respond to the grumbling?

Matthew 20:13–16 NASB95

13 “But he answered and said to one of them, ‘Friend, I am doing you no wrong; did you not agree with me for a denarius? 14 ‘Take what is yours and go, but I wish to give to this last man the same as to you.

15 ‘Is it not lawful for me to do what I wish with what is my own? Or is your eye envious because I am generous?’ 16 “So the last shall be first, and the first last.”

When you own it all, you can do what you want with it.

I like how the Holman NT Commentary explains this…

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Really, the truth is simple…

Romans 2:11 NASB95
[11] For there is no partiality with God.

We are all dependent on Him for our salvation. We are all given the same opportunity through the Gospel.

Don't you love how this parable shows God as the one who goes out and seeks those who need Him?

That sounds familiar doesn't it?

Luke 19:10 NASB95
[10] "For the Son of Man has come to seek and to save that which was lost."

Let's talk about that for just a moment. This could be the most important moment of someone's life this morning.

We've talked about our dependency, our opportunity, and God's impartiality…

But there's another part I want us to notice. And it is something that many will overlook.

Notice

Their Availability

If these workers had not been in the marketplace available to work that day, regardless of their start time, they would have never been hired.

Do you know what keeps so many people form God? They are too busy living for anything and anyone else. They are already hired out by this world system. They do not make themselves available.

Our need for availability doesn not alter or limit God's power and authority in salvation.

Scripture makes it clear…Romans 10:13

Romans 10:13 NASB95

13 for “Whoever will call on the name of the Lord will be saved.”

The enemy has gotten too many to believe they can wait. Often, people want to test out the theory and be one of the workers who works for an hour and gets paid in full.

Remember Pharoah in Exodus?

God was sending plagues upon Egypt in order to show His power and convince Pharoah to let His people go.

The first plague was Moses turning the Nile into blood, and the second was an infestation of frogs.

Exodus 8:8–9 NASB95

8 Then Pharaoh called for Moses and Aaron and said, “Entreat the Lord that He remove the frogs from me and from my people; and I will let the people go, that they may sacrifice to the Lord.”

9 Moses said to Pharaoh, “The honor is yours to tell me: when shall I entreat for you and your servants and your people, that the frogs be destroyed from you and your houses, *that* they may be left only in the Nile?”

He had a decision to make. When…when would he submit to the Lord’s will?

His answer ought to reverberate through our hearts and minds today and cause us to tremble.

Exodus 8:10 NASB95

10 Then he said, “Tomorrow…

Listen this morning folks…if you read your Bible you know that tomorrow came, but his heart was hardened.

God sent the rest of the plagues and Pharoah ended up losing his firstborn son and his life in the Red Sea.

All because he waited until tomorrow.

“preacher you are over simplifying that…” Am I?

What does scripture say about salvation?

2 Corinthians 6:2 NASB95

2 for He says, “At the acceptable time I listened to you, And on the day of salvation I helped you.” Behold, now is “the acceptable time,” behold, now is “the day of salvation”—

“Well, I don’t want to miss out on anything!” “If I give my life to Christ now, what if I lose certain things I hold dear?…”

I want to leave you today with a story. This is a story that is based on actual people. I was listening to the Deeper Podcast and heard this and it stirred my heart.

There was a father who’s son was young and did well in school. As a matter of fact, that particular semester he made straight A’s. His father who was very proud of him took him to a toy store and told him to pick out anything he wanted for doing so good in school.

His son was overwhelmed with all the choices. Seeing all the toys everywhere, he embraced his father’s leg and held it real tight. The boy looked up at his daddy and said with a big smile…”why don’t you pick for me…you always make good choices…”

Listen to me today, our God always makes good choices for us. He knows what we need. Every good and perfect gift comes form Him. He works all things together for good to those who love Him, and are called according to His purpose.

My question is simple: what if we are in the eleventh hour?

Call upon His name today. And of you are here this morning and you are saved…I need you to know that comparison is the thief of joy.

Just serve the King!